

vertigo!!

Newsletter of the New Zealand Alpine Club, Wellington Section

NO. 658 July 2003 PO BOX 1 6 2 8 W E L L I N G T O N

Club soirees are at Turnbull House,¹ on the first unimpeded Monday of every month. New and prospective members are welcome. Meet for dinner at the Backbencher public bar² at 6.30 and on to Turnbull House at 7.30 pm for a catch up. Meetings, run by President and political pundit extraordinaire Nigel Roberts, start at 8.00 pm with club business. Talks commence at 8.01 pm.



Section night: August 4th: **Dick Price, mountain doctor!**

A man who knows more about mountain medicine than all of us laid end on end will talk about aspects of his mountain days, including his ascent of Everest and his recommended tool for amputation of frost bitten toes - a can opener. Respect!



Merewyn, Garth, Alan, Caroline (in front), posing on spot height.1900m, Tukino, Sunday July 13 2003

¹ On Bowen Street, squashed behind the Treasury on Number 1 the Terrace.

² On Molesworth Street, opposite Parliament.



Section nights: Upcoming:

September 1st Short Talks Night

Back again by popular demand. To reserve your 10 minutes of fame let Caroline (cd@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz) know. No peak is too small, no expedition too short! We want to hear about it!

October 6th Lydia Bradey: Hold your breath!

The first woman to climb Mt Everest without oxygen (i.e. holding *her* breath) will give us an insight into why people have found Mongolia such a beautiful destination.

November: Phil Castle

Yep, they named Castle Hill and Castle Rock after this guy! Tales of some serious rock climbing action in Patagonia (the region, kiddies, not the clothes) and other exotic parts like El Capitan, Bhagirathi III in India, yadda, yadda.



Section trips news: Growing and sowing

Please send all your fantastic trip reports to newsletter@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz, so everyone can enjoy your stories, tall or short, fat or thin, sharp or dim. We love to know what you're up to!

Andrei and Nicki get Thai'ed up and Krabi on rock holiday

.We climbed at Railay (Krabi, Thailand) and Koh Phi Phi, one and a half hours away from Railay. We hired gear from "Phi Phi" climbers who were happy to discount their climbing package to \$45 – it is the low season! We climbed at the Ton Sai wall which has 30+ bolted routes, a 5 minute stroll from the accommodation. We did 6 climbs of French grade 5, 5+, 6A. The rock is wavy bedded limestone – lots of ledges, slopers and pinches. We enjoyed the climbing despite lack of climbing fitness. After Arapiles, and assisted by many cold showers, both our fingers (you've only got 2 fingers left? Ed.) were stripped of their hard earned calluses, leaving tender pink pads. Thankfully the rock is quite soft, and we could sink our paws into it! Enough to keep you busy for a few days and after that the taxi boat will take you anywhere for plenty of natural pro opportunities in butter soft rock.



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Alpine course Instructor Weekend of fun

Attendees at this weekend at Tukino were Peter de Joux (coordinator), Alan Lowrie, Sean Comber, Dave Shanks, Caroline Duggan, Craig Robinson, David Morgan, Jenny Henshaw, Merewyn Ellis, Michele Domaneschi, Garth London, Sharon Flood, Peter Laurenson, Blair Leslie, David Eaton, Don French, Toby Johnston and Peter Blaxter.

Accommodation at Desert Alpine's lodge was comfortable. They had hired a large generator but it failed before we arrived on Friday night, leaving only enough power from the reserve generator to run the essential lighting. The lights in the bunkrooms were not operational. The large generator was fixed on Saturday, after which there was ample electric power. The food they had supplied was more than adequate, and they were highly cooperative to ensure that our needs were being met.

Although they are not instructors, Karen Domaneschi and Angie London came up with us for the weekend. They worked hard in the kitchen to prepare meals and to clean up after us, leaving instructors with more time to focus on our desired outcomes from the weekend.

On Saturday morning the weather was good, but we needed to conduct an indoor briefing as a start to the weekend program. This developed into a session on key technical points for various syllabus items.

After lunch we split into four groups, each with a senior or experienced instructor. Each group conducted mock lessons and/or travelled around looking for places to use later with the students.

By the time dinner was completed, some instructors were keen to go out ice climbing. Others wanted to socialise in the lodge. The ice-climbing group had a great time on a calm and clear night with an almost full moon. They were climbing a 45m route on a frozen waterfall, and had taken 2-way radios for communication between themselves and also to stay in touch with the rest of us in the lodge. They returned to the lodge about midnight, and were buzzing about the good experience they had had.

On Sunday morning, I ran a quick session to explain that current practice is not to use or teach self-equalising methods for connecting multiple snow anchors. This was followed by a navigation talk by Dave Eaton.

As people headed back to the lodge, we had them look at a fully risk-managed abseil set-up.

This was a highly valuable weekend. It helps us to lift our game again. The AIC this year will be run by a very competent, enthusiastic and dedicated group of instructors, and promises to be highly successful.

Top work from Pete De Joux

Knockin' on Evans' door

In mid May, John Barnes and Pete McGregor flew from Harihari into County Stream for a quick attempt on Mt Evans (2620m).

Circling in the Hughes 500 over the névé – crevasses, icefalls, featureless snow – revealed little in the way of a possible landing site, so in a cunning attempt to prolong the spectacular ride I suggested Red Lion col. But that proved to be no go as strong gusts plucked at the helicopter so we circled down to the glacier again. Dicey, but Brian took his time, eventually finding a level spot and cautiously easing down tentative skids. We got the nod... then he was whap whapping away down valley, arcing down the County.

Silence. John's eyes disappear behind his huge grin.

Alone in the mid-morning shadow under the West face of Evans – an immense, glazed wall of chaotic rock and snow. We set up a quick camp, roped up and picked our way through the slots, stepped out from shadow and began the long plug to the col. Steeper than it looked. On the col we realised that the ridge leaning over us was a very different proposition from our preconceptions. We'd thought it would be a straightforward plod with a few steep sidles, maybe a little technical scrambling. Perhaps in some conditions it is, but for us it was iced rock showering spindrift; the buzz and whirr of ice breaking loose as the mountain's encrustation collapsed; crampons squeaking and scratching on verglas; tools picking for purchase on wrong-sloping rock; snow too soft to hold an axeplant.

Balance above nothing, rockover, push and make the move, don't think about the space... The brilliance of light and air, looking out over the sundazzled world: range upon range, deep valleys, the Tasman Sea of Cloud, Aoraki... Gravity defied by joy, on the edge of life. Birds in flight must feel like this.

Eventually we knew the climb was going nowhere. We checked the altitude at the top of a steep, constricted gully – a dead end. After much indecisive blinking, the GPS finally produced a result: "Are you indoors?" so we reversed down the gully, abseiling off a frozen-in sling – someone had come this way – then cramponed across coruscating ice, scrabbled back to Red Lion col and trudged down to the glacier camp to watch white vapour writhe around the summit and evening colours change on ice-locked rock and névé, on schrunds and crevasses.

A blast of wind whips over the col, howls down the glacier, tears at the camp then dies away. The first star winks in a darkening sky. I wake in moonlight as the glacier shudders – BOOM-BOOM-BOOM – and at dawn there's a fresh fracture line not far from the tent.

Mauve and indigo; the violet light pales and suddenly there's a patch of gold on the Red Lion ridge. The dawn of another brilliant day on the West Coast. A day of ice-encrusted moraine becoming ice-encrusted river bed boulders; of terraces infested with spear grass, snow grass, recalcitrant shrubs and piripiri; of deep drops between giant jumbled boulders; of rushing water and camera lenses fogged when the kea's at arm's length. Half an hour from dark we called it quits and camped on a small terrace to wait for the new day and the easy way out.

(Brian McBride flies a Hughes 500 from Harihari; ph. 03 753 3074; a/h 03 750 0113)

thanks to Pete McGregor



Shed 6 Queens Wharf
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Ph 04 4998898 Fax 04 4998896
wn@fergskayaks.co.nz
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**Alpine Club Members with card can climb anytime for \$8.
Monday nights show your members card and climb for \$5.**



CHAIRPERSON'S QUIZ No. 2: Answer

The chairperson's second quiz question was, What are the six Australian state summits? The answers are:

New South Wales:	Mt Kosciuszko	2,230 metres
Victoria:	Mt Bogong	1,986 metres
Queensland:	Mt Bartle Freer	1,622 metres
Tasmania:	Mt Ossa	1,617 metres
South Australia:	Mt Woodroffe	1,440 metres
Western Australia:	Mt Meharry	1,251 metres

The winner -- named at the section-night meeting on Monday, 7 July, after a live draw from all the correct entries -- was Mike Williams. He took home a bottle of Jackman Ridge wine.



...and the riddle of the Chairperson's new problem number 3 – graded V15!

Who am I? (word to thickies – I can tell you right now that the answer's not Nigel Roberts! Nor is it a Satre-inspired existential question neither! Ed.)

*The first letter of one my names
Comes from one end of the alphabet.
I was the first person to climb A,
The highest mountain in a country beginning with A.
There's also a ridge named after me
On another mountain known as A.
This other mountain, which also has another name,
Is the highest mountain in a country known as A,
But that country is also known by another name,
One word of which begins with ...
The first letter of one of my names!*

Email your answers to the chairperson of the Wellington section by no later than noon on Saturday, 2 August. The chairperson's email address is <chairperson@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz>.

The winner will be announced at the 4 August section-night meeting. The prize will be a bottle of wine from a country beginning with A!



New Zealand Alpine Journal 2003: Contributions please!

Contributions sought... Yup — it's that time of the year again; time to put pen to paper, fingers to keyboard and start sorting out those slides.

We want *your* words and photos. Principally we seek reports of this year's most note-worthy climbs (either new climbs or repeats), articles or essays from any aspect of the greater sphere of climbing, local area reports, and yes... obituaries. As always photographs and artwork are welcomed.

If you have an idea you wish to discuss or any questions, or a submission, don't hesitate to contact the editor:

Mark Watson – NZAJ Editor
(day) 03 377 7595, (eve) 03 942 3312
editor@alpineclub.org.nz
PO Box 786, Christchurch.

CLOSING DATE 1st SEPT 2003



Our website

- Check out our web site: www.nzalpine.wellington.net.nz !
- Join the email discussion group!
- New photos and trip reports up!



NZAC National Instruction Programme

Course Numbers are limited so book early! Fully qualified alpine guides or rock instructors will be used to lead all courses and there will be an instructor - student ration of 1:4 ensuring an excellent learning environment.

Intermediate Alpine Instruction (Two Days) \$130

2-3 August Mt Ruapehu

Intermediate Rock Instruction (Two Days) \$99

23-24 October, Otago
1-2 November, Canterbury
23-24 October, Auckland
1-2 November, Wellington

Intermediate- Advanced Mountaineering (Five Days) \$950

3-7 January 2004, Unwin Hut Mt Cook
10-14 January 2004 Unwin Hut Mt Cook

Richard Wesley, National Administrator
Phone: 03 377 7595
Email: richard@alpineclub.org.nz

Banff Festival of Mountain Films coming to Wellington!!!

The NZAC Wellington Section is pleased to bring the best of the Banff Festival of Mountain Films to Wellington for the first time. This international festival will be an evening of films on all types of climbing as well as mountain culture and other mountain-related escapades. Guaranteed to be a fun and entertaining evening.

When: Friday Sept 5th at 7:30PM

Where: Memorial Theatre, Victoria University

Tickets: \$15.00

We will be having a one night only pre-sale of tickets at the August 4th section night. This is your chance to assure yourself of a ticket as there are only 375 seats. Cash only please.

BYE MARIA – The Wellington Section Committee would like to thank Maria Cassidy for her hard work over the last few years, particularly in sub editing vertiGO and arranging all the Newsletter Printing and Folding! We hope you enjoy your new found spare time and put it too good use climbing mountains.



HANGDOG INDOOR CLIMBING CAVERN

Come down and see us for all your climbing and bouldering needs. We have heaps of good routes from grade 14 through to 30. We have the only bouldering room in Wellington, which we have just enlarged to help aspiring and existing climbers become STRONGER.

Remember that it only costs NZAC members \$8.00 to climb with ID, and you get 20% off all climbing gear that you purchase from us. If we don't have what you want we will get it.

Climbers helping climbers

HangDog and Top Adventures
453 Hutt Rd
Lower Hutt
(04) 589 9181

And here are the club trips...

Wellington Section Trips

Trips are a key part of the section, so if anyone has an idea about a trip, no matter how vague, come and chat to either Jenny Henshaw or Mike Williams.

Jenny (alpinetrips@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz) is the person to contact about alpine trips and Mike (rocktrips@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz) can help you out with planning rock climbing trips.

Trips can be of any length, any level of difficulty, and any size. Simply email us, or approach us at the monthly meeting, and we can help you get going on a safe and enjoyable trip.

See you in the hills!

Trips currently on the calendar...

Whangaehu Ski-Touring	<i>Weekend August 2-3</i>
<i>Trip type:</i> Ski Touring	<i>Level:</i> Intermediate
<i>Organiser:</i> Mike Peat, email: mike.peat@xtra.co.nz , 04 479 5521 (h)	
Based from the club hut, intermediate skiing ability required - and lots of enthusiasm.	

Ruapehu Alpine Style!!	<i>Weekend August 30-31</i>
<i>Trip type:</i> Mountaineering	<i>Level:</i> Intermediate - Advanced
<i>Organiser:</i> Mike Peat, email: mike.peat@xtra.co.nz , 04 479 5521 (h)	
Access the bush edge via 4WD from the south, climb the spur to the west of the Wahianoa River, camp on the Glacier and traverse Girdlestone, Tahurangi and Mitre. Suitable for last years AIC students or anyone who hasn't explored this remote part of the mountain. A good level of fitness is required.	

Ski Touring Traverse of Ruapehu	<i>Weekend September 13-14</i>
<i>Trip type:</i> Ski Touring	<i>Level:</i> Intermediate
<i>Organiser:</i> Michele Domaneschi, email md@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz	
Dust of those old skis, and head for the hills with Michele and friends, to explore the crater area of Ruapehu, crossing from Whakapapa to Turoa. More details to follow.	

Girdlestone	<i>Weekend September 20-21</i>
<i>Trip type:</i> Alpine, Various	<i>Level:</i> Intermediate - Advanced
<i>Organiser:</i> TBC, email alpinetrips@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz	
The plan is to split into small groups and do various activities (weather and conditions dependent), e.g., North ridge of Girdlestone/South West face of Girdlestone (technical route), Tahurangi summit, ice-fall climbing, snow boarding or skiing, or the climbing wall at National Park! We aim to be based at the Massey University ski hut, 25mins from Ohakune.	

Wharepapa Rock Climbing	<i>Weekend September 27 – 28</i>
<i>Trip type:</i> Rock Climbing	<i>Level:</i> All

Organiser: Mike Williams, email mw@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz
A weekend away rock climbing at Wharepapa in the central North Island.

Taranaki Ice Climbing	<i>Weekend October 4-5</i>
<i>Trip type:</i> Ice Climbing	<i>Level:</i> Intermediate
<i>Organiser:</i> Steve Hart, email sh@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz	
A chance to get up to the summit or ice climb on some of the crags near Tauranga Lodge. Participants need to be at least post AIC level as this is not a novice trip.	

Arthurs Pass / Castle Hill Exploration	<i>Long Weekend October 25-26-27</i>
<i>Trip type:</i> Rock / Mountaineering	<i>Level:</i> All
<i>Organiser:</i> Mike Williams, email mw@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz	
A trip with everything, the plan involves a mix of rock climbing at Castle Hill and Flock Hill, and day trips with mountaineering objectives such as Rolleston, Phipps, or possibly a 2 dayer to Franklin. Details depend on ambitions and abilities in the group. Trip to be based at NZAC hut in Arthurs Pass Village.	

Aoraki / Mt Cook National Park	<i>Long Weekend October 25-26-27</i>
<i>Trip type:</i> Mountaineering	<i>Level:</i> Intermediate - Advanced
<i>Organiser:</i> Jenny Henshaw, email jh@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz	
An extended long weekend, probably involving one day off work, with the aim of climbing either Mt Dixon from the Plateau area, or the Minarets, from the Tasman Valley. Details to follow.	

Paynes Ford	<i>Weekend November 8-9</i>
<i>Trip type:</i> Rock / Mountaineering	<i>Level:</i> All
<i>Organiser:</i> Mike Williams, email mw@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz	
A weekend to the top-o-the-south, rock climbing at Paynes Ford.	

Tasman Saddle	<i>Week November 29- December 7</i>
<i>Trip type:</i> Mountaineering	<i>Level:</i> Intermediate - Advanced
<i>Organiser:</i> Caroline Duggan, email cd@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz Garth London, email gl@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz	
Get in quick if you're keen for a trip to Tasman Saddle. Objectives are a plenty and great company is guaranteed. This trip will be limited in number and based on a first in, first served principle. There are currently a few spaces left, after that its onto the waiting list.	

Hopkins Valley	<i>Week January 3 – 11, 2004</i>
<i>Trip type:</i> Mountaineering / Rock	<i>Level:</i> Intermediate - Advanced
<i>Organiser:</i> Steve Hart, email sh@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz	
A week away from the tourist hoards, exploring this great area just south of Cook/Aoraki, with tramping and easy summits through to cragging and snowy mountains.	

Taranaki Rock Trip	<i>Long weekend January 17-18-19</i>
<i>Trip type:</i> Rock Climbing	<i>Level:</i> All
<i>Organiser:</i> TBC email rocktrips@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz	

Nepal	<i>TBC</i>
<i>Trip type:</i> Overseas expedition	<i>Level:</i> Intermediate - Advanced
<i>Organiser:</i> Steve Hart, sh@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz	
How about a slightly longer trip to Nepal in October/November 2004?? Several people have indicated interest in a section climbing trip to attempt several trekking peaks - Island Peak and Lubeje East have been suggested as reasonably straightforward objectives. This could include a non-climbing trek party also. <i>*Update*</i>: Interest in this trip steadily grows. With the changing regulations so too do the objectives, one of which is to scale Mt Have-a-Good-Time. Trekking options will be part of this trip. We will be aiming to stay away from the Everest circus while still utilising the ease of logistics. One of our goals will be an unclimbed peak up to 6500m. People who are interested and willing to be part of a team effort can contact Steve Hart.	

Chile	<i>TBC</i>
<i>Trip type:</i> Overseas expedition	<i>Level:</i> Intermediate - Advanced
<i>Organiser:</i> Toto Gronlund, toto.high@ntl-world.com	
The English alpine club are organising a trip to Patagonia in 2004, if you would like more information, contact Toto Gronlund.	





Wellington Section Directory: 2003 contact list

Position	Name	E-mail Alias*	Phone
Patron	Judy Reid	N/A	N/A
Chairperson	Nigel Roberts	CHAIRPERSON or NR	(04) 475 7543
Vice Chairpersons	Pete De Joux	PDJ or PD	(04) 478 1017
	Steve Hart	SH	N/A
Secretary	Rachael Schmidt	SECRETARY or RS	(04) 470 4479
Treasurer	Caroline Duggan	TREASURER or CD	(04) 475 5542
National Representative	Caroline Duggan	CD	(04) 475 5542
Instruction: AIC	Pete de Joux	AIC	(04) 478 1017
Instruction: RIC	Scott Taylor	SPRINGROCK	N/A
Trips: Alpine	Jenny Henshaw	ALPINETRIPS or JH	N/A
Trips: Rock	Mike Williams	ROCKTRIPS or MW	(04) 973 2995
Library	Derek Richardson	LIBRARY	N/A
	Peter Shanahan	PS2	(04) 934 7926
Committee Members	Lynn Ayers	LA	(04) 977 4914
	Michele Domaneschi	MD	N/A
	Jenny Henshaw	JH	N/A
	Garth London	GL	(04) 479 2984
	Alan Lowrie	AL	N/A
	Mike O'Brien	MOB	(04) 380 0913
	Peter Shanahan	PS2	(04) 934 7926
	Mike Williams	MW	(04) 973 2995
National President	Dave Bamford	DB	N/A
Palmerston North Contact	John Barnes	JB	(06) 357 0654
Newsletter Editor	Simon Chapple	NEWSLETTER or SC	N/A
Section Night Admin	Kara Lipski	KL	N/A
Webmeister	Jane Furkert	WEBMASTER or JF	N/A

* Email address is alias@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz, eg: secretary@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz